Contradictions-Tracking Poems

By Adrienne Rich

INTRODUCTION

In the words of Adrienne Rich: The most notable fact our culture imprints on women is the sense of our limits. The most important thing one woman can do for another is to illuminate and expand her sense of actual possibilities. Through her poetry . . . . Rich chronicles her evolving understanding of intimacy. Her poetry expresses not only the experiences of a woman, a feminist, and a lesbian, but the experiences of all human beings working to maintain intimate relationships in a difficult world. Contradictions – Tracking Poems by Adrienne Rich

Look: this is January the worst onslaught
is ahead of us Don't be lured
by these soft grey afternoons these sunsets cut
from pink and violet tissue-paper by the thought
the days are lengthening
Don't let the solstice fool you:
our lives will always be
a stew of contradictions

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the worst moment of winter can come in April
when the peepers are stubbornly still and our bodies
plod on without conviction
and our thoughts cramp down before the sheer
arsenal of everything that tries us:
this battering, blunt-edged life

Heart of cold. Bones of cold. Scalp
of cold.
the grey the black the blond
the red
hairs on a skull of cold. Within that skull
the thought of war the sovereign thought
the coldest of all thought. Dreaming shut down
everything kneeling down to cold intelligence
smirking with cold memory
squashed and frozen cold breath
half held-in for cold. The freezing people
of a freezing nation eating
luxury food or garbage
frozen tongues licking the luxury meat

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or the pizza-crust the frozen eyes
welded to other eyes also frozen
Heart of cold Intelligence of cold
My country wedged fast in history
stuck in the ice

I'm calling you up tonight
as I might call up a friend as I might call up a
ghost
to ask what you intend to do
with the rest of your life. Sometimes you act
as if you have all the time there is.
I worry about you when I see this.
The prime of life, old age
aren't what they used to be;
making a good death isn't either,
now you can walk around the comer of a wall
and see a light
that already has blown your past away.
Somewhere in Boston beautiful literature
is being read around the clock

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by writers to signify
their dislike of this.
I hope you've got something in mind.
I hope you have some idea
about the rest of your life.

I feel signified by pain
from my breastbone through my left shoulder
down through my elbow into my wrist is a thread of pain
I am typing this instead of writing by hand
because my wrist on the right side
blooms and rushes with pain
like a neon bulb
You ask me how I'm going to live
the rest of my life
Well, nothing is predictable with pain
Did the old poets write of this?
--in its odd spaces, free,
many have sung and battled --
But I'm already living the rest of my life
not under conditions of my choosing

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wired into pain
rider on the slow train

Night over the great and the little worlds
of Brooklyn the shredded communities
in Chicago Argentina Poland
in Holyoke Massachusetts Amsterdam
Manchester
England
Night falls the day of atonement begins
in how many divided hearts how many defiant
lives
Toronto Managua St. Johnsbury
and the great and little worlds of the women
Something ancient passes across the earth
lifting the dust of the blasted ghettos
You ask if I will eat and I say, Yes,
I have never fasted
but something crosses my life
not a shadow the reflection of a fire

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I came out of the hospital like a woman
who'd watched a massacre
not knowing how to tell
my adhesions the lingering infections
from the pain on the streets
In my room on Yom Kippur they took me off morphine
I saw shadows on the wall the dying and the
dead
They said Christian Phalangists did it
then Kol Nidre on the radio and my own
unhoused spirit trying to find a home
Was it then or another day
in what order did it happen
I thought *They call this elective surgery*
but we all have died of this.
Violence as purification: the one idea.
One massacre great enough to undo another
one last-ditch operation to solve the problem
of the old operation that was bungled
Look: I have lain on their tables under their tools

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under their drugs from the center of
my body
a voice bursts against these methods
(wherever you made a mistake
batter with radiation defoliate c ut
away)
and yes, there are merciful debridements
but bums turn into rotting flesh
for reasons of vengeance and neglect.
I have been too close to septic too many times
to play with either violence or non-violence.

Lately in my dreams I hear long sentences
meaningless in ordinary American
like, *Your mother, too, was a missionary of poets*
and in another dream one of my old teachers
shows me a letter of reference
he has written for me, in a language
I know to be English but cannot understand,
telling me it's in "transformational grammar"
and that the student who typed the letter

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does not understand this grammar either.
Lately I dreamed about my father,
how I found him, alive, seated on an old chair.
I think what he said to me was,
You don't know how lonely I am.

The problem, unstated till now, is how
to live in a damaged body
in a world where pain is meant to be gagged
uncured un-grieved-over The problem is
to connect, without hysteria, the pain
of anyone's body with the pain of the body's world
For it is the body's world
they are trying to destroy forever
The best world is the body's world
filled with creatures filled with dread
misshapen so yet the best we have
our raft among the abstract worlds
and how I longed to live on this earth
walking her boundaries never counting the
cost.

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In a bald skull sits our friend in a helmet
of third-degree bums
her quizzical melancholy grace
her irreplaceable self in utter peril
In the radioactive desert walks a woman
in a black dress white-haired steady
as the luminous hand of a clock
in circles she walks knitting
and unknitting her scabbed fingers
Her face is expressionless shall we pray to her
shall we speak of the loose pine-needles how
they shook
like the pith of country summers
from the sacks of pitchblende ore in the tin-roofed
shack
where it all began
Shall we accuse her of denial
first of the self then of the mixed virtue
of the purest science shall we be wise for
her

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in hindsight shall we scream *It has come to this*
Shall we praise her shall we let her wander
the atomic desert in peace?

You know the Government must have pushed them to
settle,
the chemical industries and pay
that hush-money to the men
who landed out there at twenty not for belief
but because of who they were and were called
psychos
when they said their bodies contained dioxin
like memories they didn't want to keep
whose kids came out deformed
You know nothing has changed no respect or
grief
for the losers of a lost war everyone hated
nobody sent them to school like heroes
if they started sueing for everything that was done
there would be no end there would be a
beginning

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My country wedged fast in history
stuck in the ice

The Tolstoyans the Afro-American slaves
knew this: you could be killed
for teaching people to read and write
I used to think the worst affliction
was to be forbidden pencil and paper
well, Ding Ling recited poems to prison walls
for years of the Cultural Revolution
and truly, the magic of written characters
looms and dwindles shrinks small grows
swollen
depending on where you stand
and what is in your hand
and who can read and why
I think now the worst affliction
is not to know who you are or have been
I have learned this in part
from writers Reading and writing
aren't sacred yet people have been killed

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as if they were

You who think I find words for everything
this is enough for now
cut it short cut loose from my words.
You for whom I write this
in the night hours when the wrecked cartilage
sifts round the mystical jointure of the bones
when the insect of detritus crawls
from shoulder to elbow to wristbone
remember: the body's pain and the pain on the
streets
are not the same but you can learn
from the edges that blur O, you who love clear
edges
more than anything watch the edges that blur

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